LOOKING AHEAD: WHAT TO WATCH IN 2026

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In 2026, the global landscape will be shaped by the convergence of shifting international alliances, critical national elections, and conflicting multilateral priorities.



2026 headline items

India chairs BRICS (18th Leaders' Summit)
India will assume the BRICS rotating chair and will host the 18th BRICS leaders' meeting. Expect the agenda to prioritise digital public infrastructure, South–South cooperation, finance and development alternatives to the traditional Bretton Woods institutions.

The United States holds the G20 presidency and summit
The US will hold the 2026 G20 presidency and host the leaders' summit. Watch for US priorities on trade, technology governance, and alliances with a newly enlarged G20 that has now included the African Union as a permanent participant.

African Union influence continues to grow
The AU's permanent role in the G20 means that Africa's policy priorities (industrialisation, commodity value chains, debt architecture, climate finance and food security) will be on the table in a sustained way in 2026. Expect African delegations to push for tangible finance and investment commitments.

Dates to pin to your calendar

COP31
Countries are positioning bids (Australia has mounted a high-profile bid for Adelaide). Climate finance and industrial transition (green hydrogen, critical minerals) will be prioritised.

UN General Assembly (81st session)
The annual UNGA high-level week, opening on 8 September, will again be a stage for G20/BRICS leaders to set rhetoric and soft commitments ahead of summit cycles.

UN Security Council non-permanent seats election
Elections for rotating UNSC seats will happen in mid-2026; results will play a role in Africa's representation in a body central to geopolitical security discussions.

Elections that will shape geopolitics

United States - 3 November (midterm elections)
Congressional control will shape US domestic political bandwidth on trade and foreign policy during its G20 year.

Brazil - 4 October (general election)
Brazil's national vote will have an effect on South America's posture in BRICS, regional trade and climate policy coordination.
India - multiple state assembly and Rajya Sabha cycles
State results and upper-house composition matter for New Delhi's domestic mandate to chair BRICS and push international initiatives.

Multiple African national elections
Several African countries are scheduled for national polls in 2026, which will influence Africa's internal policy priorities (industrial policy, land/food security, natural resource governance) and shape the AU's negotiating posture at the G20/BRICS tables.

The key policy battles to follow

Development finance and the NDB vs. Bretton Woods architecture
BRICS will press New Development Bank lending and alternative financing vehicles; watch whether this yields concrete project pipelines in Africa and new currency-swap frameworks.

Technology and data governance (AI, data flows, digital public infrastructure)
Both BRICS and the G20 will debate rules for data, cross-border digital public infrastructure and AI governance; India's BRICS chair is likely to spotlight digital public goods and data sovereignty.

Climate finance and just transitions
COP31 and the G20 will be coordination points for financing decarbonisation, especially for Africa's energy transition and critical minerals supply chains.

Debt, trade and industrial policy for Africa
With the AU in the G20 and stronger BRICS-Africa ties, expect pressure for coordinated approaches to debt relief, local value-addition and preferential investment frameworks.

Three practical signals to watch

Summit deliverables vs. declarations: compare leaders' communiqués (BRICS and G20) against binding financing or trade commitments; language is cheap, new public finance flows are not.

Elections that change major economies: US midterms and Brazil's general election will shift bargaining power and the tone of cooperation or confrontation on trade and tech.

AU influence tested in practice: watch whether the AU's G20 seat delivers concrete policy wins on climate finance, food security and industrial policy for Africa.